

THE LITERAL GENIE LESSON • LESSON 1 OF 6

How to Talk to AI



45 minutes, no prep. The hook: AI is a literal genie — it grants what you SAID, not what you MEANT. Students learn the two human jobs in a good AI task: the prompt and the check. Stands alone.

AT A GLANCE

TIME	MATERIALS	TECH NEEDED	PREP
45 min	Cursed Wish Repair Shop worksheet (2 pages, 1 per student; typeable PDF included) · Slides (optional) · board for P.R.O. · Teacher Guide (Scoring Guidance, P.R.O. sentence starters) · pens	None — runs fully unplugged. Optional: a projector for the slides; one AI tool (ChatGPT, Claude, or Gemini) on your screen for the Showcase.	Print worksheets (and Teacher Guide p.3 if you use the Support/ELL sentence starters). That's it.

OBJECTIVES

ISTE 1.5.c

ISTE 1.3.b

CCSS ELA W.6.4

- Show how a vague prompt lets the genie choose (and why that produces a worse answer). (*Exit Ticket #1, part two*)
- Apply **P.R.O.** (Purpose, Requirements, Output) to write a clear prompt. (*Wish repairs 1–3; Exit Ticket #1*)
- Evaluate a sample AI answer: pick what to double-check and name a real source. (*Exit Ticket #2*)

♦ WARM-UP — THE WORST GENIE EVER (8 MIN)

You are a genie who grants wishes *exactly as worded*. Take 3–4 wishes and ruin every one, cheerfully:

"I wish I was rich." → "Done. Your name is now Rich."

"I wish for a million dollars." → "Granted — one million dollars, in play money."

"I wish school was over." → "Granted. The school building is now over... there."

"I wish I was the best gamer alive." → "Granted. You are now the only gamer alive."

Then ask: **"Whose fault was that — the genie's, or the wish's?"** **Bridge:** "AI works like that genie. It can't see what you MEANT. It only sees what you SAID, and it guesses the rest. A good AI job goes human, AI, human: you start it with the wish, the genie does the middle, and you check what comes back. Today you get good at both human parts."

What if a wish is inappropriate? Don't play it: "The genie doesn't grant that one. Next wish." Nobody volunteers? Wish first yourself: "I wish for a snack" → "Granted: one grain of rice."

Transition: "So how do you write a wish a genie can't twist? You leave it no wiggle room."

DIRECT INSTRUCTION — PARTS OF A GENIE-PROOF WISH (10 MIN)

"Every genie-proof wish has three parts." Write **P.R.O.** on the board as you go:

P — Purpose. What you want + who it's for. "Explain photosynthesis to a 6th grader" beats "explain photosynthesis."

R — Requirements. The rules: length, tone, format, include / leave out. This is what stops the twist.

O — Output. What should the finished answer look like? A list? A paragraph? A table? A plan?

Watch one get fixed — build the repair on the board, naming each part as you add it. **Cursed wish:** "help with my history essay" → **Genie-proof P.R.O. prompt:** "I'm writing a 7th grade history essay on the printing press. Give me 3 thesis statements and 2 pieces of evidence for each, as a bullet list. Don't write it for me." With devices: run it live.

DIRECT INSTRUCTION (CONT.)

Say it plainly: "AI is your editor, not your ghostwriter. An editor gives a second opinion on YOUR work. A ghostwriter writes the whole thing and lets you put your name on it. Remember how that prompt ended: *Don't write it for me.*"

What if someone says the fixed prompt is "too long"? Count it: three sentences. "Three sentences now, or a pile of junk to dig through later. Your call."

Hand-out / transition: "Your turn. Page 1: three kids typed cursed wishes. Fix all three. Every wish gets P, R, and O. Solo. Ten minutes."

ACTIVITY — CURSED WISH REPAIR SHOP (20 MIN)

1. **Repair (10 min):** Solo, students fix Amara's, Mateo's, and Yuki's cursed wishes on page 1 with all three P.R.O. parts. Circulate; read a stuck student's repair aloud in a genie voice.

What if a student writes nearly the same repair three times? "What does Mateo need that Yuki doesn't?" A plan is not a story, so the O part has to change. **Finished early?** Extension below.

Swap: "Pens down. Swap sheets. You are now the Worst Genie Ever, and page 2 is where you do your damage. Partner A is the partner whose first name comes first in the alphabet. Partner A goes first."

2. **Break it (7 min):** Partner A goes first, about 3 minutes: for each of B's wishes, A puts a ✓ under every part it has on the Genie-Proof Checklist, then twists it out loud to B. Then B does the same for A. Both write their sneakiest twist on the sheet they hold, and sheets go back. A wish that twists needs more rules.

What if a partner puts a ✓ in every box without trying? Make them say the twist out loud. No twist? The ✓ stands. A twist? Cross out the Genie-test ✓ and write the twist.

Swap back: "Sheets back with their owners. Genies, point at the ONE wish on your partner's sheet you could NOT twist. That's the one we want to hear."

3. **Showcase (3 min):** 2–3 pairs read a "cursed → genie-proof" before-and-after. With devices: run ONE live instead of the third reading.

What if the live AI answer is bad anyway? Perfect. "Which part of the wish let it do that?" The class adds a rule. Run it again only if you have the minute.

Into the exit ticket: "Your OWN sheet, bottom of page 2. Before you write, one more rule about genies."

EXIT TICKET — LAST CHECK (7 MIN: 1 + 6)

First minute — the trickster rule: "Genies are tricksters. AI can grant your wish with made-up facts and sound totally sure. A name, a date, a number: if you can check it, check it somewhere real before you use it." **Six minutes, solo:** students answer Exit Ticket #1 and #2 exactly as printed on page 2. Collect. The key is in the Teacher Guide only.

What if a student says "it all sounds right"? "Which sentence has a number or a date in it? Start there."

DIFFERENTIATION

- **Support:** P.R.O. sentence starters (Teacher Guide);
- **Extension:** On the back of page 2, write a wish that CAN'T be genie-proofed in under 50 words. Then explain why.
- **ELL:** The sentence starters double as language frames. Students can draft in their strongest language first, then translate.
- **No-device classrooms:** Built in — the teacher and partners ARE the genie. Just leave out the "with devices" lines.